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Sturgeon Bay discontinues the use of Flock cameras

The Sturgeon Bay Common Council voted to end its contract with Flock after two years, citing resident concerns over data privacy and personal liberties.



Abbey Hamachek

A Flock camera pictured in Sturgeon Bay.

By: Abbey Hamachek



Posted

[Abbey Hamachek](#) I'm your Lakeshore neighborhood reporter.

STURGEON BAY (NBC 26) — The Sturgeon Bay Common Council has decided to discontinue the use of Flock license plate reading cameras following public pushback over privacy concerns.

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The cameras, which capture the license plates of passing vehicles, have been used in the city for two years. Sturgeon Bay police said the cameras are no longer in use, though it will take a couple of weeks for the company to remove them.

Residents pushed to remove the system from the city budget due to trust issues regarding surveillance.

"There was a space to come in and challenge it and try to get it off the budget," Michelle Hroma said.

"Given the federal administration right now, it's a scary country to be in and that data could be in the wrong hands and who knows how it can be abused," Hroma said.

Matt Peter called the system invasive.

"The drawbacks of the Flock system are so detrimental to our personal privacy and our personal liberties that the payoff is just not there," Peter said.

Sturgeon Bay Assistant Police Chief Dan Brinkman said the technology has made a real difference in investigations, helping with theft cases and finding missing people.

"Is there any technology that is perfect? The answer is no. Does it greatly enhance our abilities? Absolutely. That's what's frustrating," Brinkman said.

Brinkman noted that outside agencies cannot access the data without permission from Sturgeon Bay police.

"I pray to God that we don't have a child abduction, because then we are back to square one," Brinkman said.

Even with the contract ending in Sturgeon Bay, Peter remains concerned about the technology's presence in neighboring communities.

"Absolutely. I think that it's a concern anywhere that Flock is being used," Peter said.

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